

Health Information Paper Instructions

In this assignment, you will evaluate how controversial health topics are communicated to the public. This is NOT a persuasive paper. Instead of arguing for/ against a belief, you will analyze how scientific evidence is communicated, interpreted, and framed across multiple sources. Your goal is to analyze how information is communicated, not whether you personally agree with the conclusions. Throughout this assignment you will practice identifying scientific evidence, recognizing bias, separating fact from interpretation, and thinking critically about how communication style impacts health decisions.

Topics

For this paper, you will choose to focus on ONE of two topics: Cannabis for Medical Use OR COVID-19 Vaccines. For each topic, I have found five sources that address each concern (which have as much overlap as possible), and these are the five sources you will use in your paper. You are welcome to read through the sources on each topic before making your selection, but you will only focus on one topic in your actual paper.

Breakdown of Paper

This paper will be broken into sections for an introduction (which has no header), a section for each of the five sources (with a header stating each source), a section for a critical evaluation of how the health topic was communicated, and a personal reflection. The paper should be in APA format, written in Times New Roman, 12-point font, and double-spaced. There should be separate pages for the cover page and references. A template is provided on Canvas, so students can edit directly into the document, without needing to change the formatting.

1. Introduction (5%)

To begin the paper, you will introduce the topic you selected, and address how it relates to health decisions. You will explain how it is controversial by stating the two main perspectives. This section should not exceed one paragraph, only serving as a brief introduction to the topic, as if the reader was naïve to the topic.

2. Source Evaluations (10% x 5 Sources)

You will critically evaluate each source, focusing on how the information on the health topic is communicated. You will BRIEFLY evaluate each of the following aspects:

- I. What statistics/ data are presented? (An overall review, not a re-listing of results)
- II. Is the source focused on evidence or interpretation (or how much is it focused on either)?
- III. What appears to be the purpose of the source (e.g., informing the public, persuading readers, advocating for a specific policy, etc.)?
- IV. What is the tone of the source (e.g., reassuring, skeptical, alarming, etc.) and how does that tone shape the impact to the reader?
- V. What are some indicators of bias in the source?

You must address all five aspects of the evaluation for each source, but the order in which you address the five concerns is up to you. It is important that your evaluation of each aspect is concise and data driven. This means that you should address each aspect in roughly 1-2 sentences, using brief quotations to back up your statements (so ~5-10 sentences per source).

NOTE: This is an evaluation of communication style, NOT a bibliography. You should not be summarizing the source; you should be critiquing the source. Your evaluation of each source should not exceed 250 words.

3. Critical Evaluation of Health Communication (15%)

After analyzing all five sources, you will evaluate the broader patterns across the sources. You should address the following questions:

- I. Who can be subject to bias when communicating health information (e.g., journalists, political party members, government officials, researchers, organizations, institutions, etc.)?
- II. How might the source a person reads influence their interpretation of the research on the topic?
- III. How might the biases and communication styles impact health decisions by the general public?
- IV. What factors should be considered when evaluating information about health?

When you address these questions, you should synthesize the information you learned across all the sources to critically evaluate how the public should approach health information. As with the source evaluations, you will need to be succinct, and data driven. This section should be between 200-400 words.

4. Personal Reflection (5%)

To complete the paper, you will write one paragraph reflecting on what you learned throughout the assignment. You are encouraged to address topics such as your original expectations versus actual experience, anything surprising you encountered, and how this may relate to health decisions you will make throughout your life. As this is the only section where opinion is allowed, you are welcome to address any emotional shifts or conflicts you experienced while researching the topic. The paragraph summarizing your experience should not exceed 250 words.

5. References (10%)

The reference list should include all five sources included in the paper, in alphabetical order and hanging indent. Each reference needs to be the appropriate APA format for that source style. You are welcome (and encouraged) to use the following examples as a guide:

For research articles:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here*, #(#), #-#. (replace this line with DOI link)

OR, if the article has an ID instead of page numbers:

Author, A. A., & Author, B. B (20##). Article title goes here. *Journal Title Goes Here*, #(#), Article #. (replace this line with DOI link)

Note: see APA guidelines/ examples here: <https://apastyle.apa.org/style-grammar-guidelines/references/examples/journal-article-references>

For websites (including news websites):

Author, A. A. (Year, Month Day). Article title goes here. *News Source Name Goes Here*. (replace this line with URL link)

Note: see APA guidelines/ examples here: <https://apastyle.apa.org/style-grammar-guidelines/references/examples/webpage-website-references>

As a reminder, you will need to use the appropriate in-text citations for all sources.

Writing (15%)

The entire paper should be in black text, Times New Roman 12-point font, and double spaced. Indent new paragraphs. Paragraphs should be three to eight sentences. Do NOT add extra spaces between paragraphs. Use full sentences and in-text citations. There should be separate pages for the cover page and references. Please check thoroughly for grammatical errors and unclear sentences. The points for the writing portion are split 5% APA format, 10% writing style.

Policies

AI Use

The use of AI platforms is NOT permitted for this assignment. Use of AI will result in an immediate zero and potential academic dishonesty ramifications.

Late Policy

As per the syllabus, there will be a 10-point deduction for every day late. As students are aware of their paper for a month, and the paper is submitted online, extensions will not be granted based on events that occur the day the paper is due.

Canvas Rubric

Introduction (5 points)

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Clearly introduces the selected health topic. -Accurately explains how the topic relates to health decisions. -Clearly identifies the two main perspectives contributing to controversy. -Concise and appropriate background for a reader unfamiliar with the topic.	-Topic introduced and controversy mentioned. -Some explanation of relevance to health decisions. -One element slightly vague or underdeveloped.	-Topic mentioned but explanation of controversy unclear. -Limited explanation of health relevance.	-Introduction missing key elements OR unclear description of the health topic.

Sources (10 points each)

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
-All five evaluation elements clearly addressed. -Analysis is concise and evidence-based. -Specific quotes or examples support claims. -Evaluation critiques communication style rather than summarizing the article. -Word limit followed (≤ 250 words).	-All elements addressed but one is somewhat vague or underdeveloped. -Some evidence or examples used but not consistently. -Minor drift into summary rather than critique.	-One or more required evaluation elements missing OR poorly explained. -Limited supporting evidence from the source. -Excessive summary.	-Multiple required elements missing. -Little or no evidence supporting claims. -Primarily summarizes article rather than evaluating communication style.

Critical Evaluation of Health Communication (15 points)

Excellent – 15 pts	Proficient – 12 pts	Developing – 9 pts	Needs Improvement – 6 pts or below
-Thoughtful synthesis across all five sources. -Clearly addresses all 4 questions specified in instructions -Uses examples from multiple sources. -Demonstrates strong critical thinking.	-Addresses all prompts but analysis may rely more on explanation than synthesis. -Limited use of examples from sources.	-Addresses only some prompts OR responses are brief and underdeveloped. -Minimal connection to source analysis.	-Missing key prompts OR lacks meaningful analysis of health communication.

Personal Reflection (5 points)

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Clearly reflects on expectations vs actual experience. -Discusses what was surprising or informative. -Thoughtfully connects learning to future health decision-making.	-Addresses reflection prompts but explanation is somewhat brief or vague.	-Addresses only part of the reflection prompt OR provides minimal insight.	-Reflection missing key elements OR lacks meaningful engagement.

APA References

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
-All sources correctly formatted in APA style. -References listed alphabetically in hanging indent. -In-text citations correctly match reference list.	-Minor APA formatting errors in references OR in-text citations.	-Multiple APA errors OR missing elements in references.	-Major APA errors OR references incomplete/missing sources.

WRITING:**APA Format (5%)**

Excellent – 5 pts	Proficient – 4 pts	Developing – 3 pts	Needs Improvement – 2 pts or below
-Times New Roman, 12-point font, double spaced, black text. -Correct use of provided template. -Separate cover page and reference page. -Correct section headings used.	-Minor formatting inconsistencies but all major requirements present.	-Repeated formatting inconsistencies OR template not used correctly.	-Major formatting problems (incorrect font, spacing, missing required pages, etc.).

Grammar and Clarity (10%)

Excellent – 10 pts	Proficient – 8 pts	Developing – 6 pts	Needs Improvement – 4 pts or below
-Clear academic tone. -Sentences are grammatically correct. -Writing is concise and logically organized. -Very few spelling or punctuation errors.	-Generally clear writing with a few minor grammar or punctuation errors.	-Multiple grammar or clarity issues. -Some awkward phrasing or unclear sentences.	-Frequent grammar errors OR writing difficult to follow.

APA Checklist for References

NOTE: Each source is worth 2 points. Here is a breakdown of those points, based on the source type.

For a research article:

- ___/0.1 – Alphabetic order
- ___/0.1 – Hanging indent
- ___/0.3 – Article in-text citation
- ___/0.3 – Author(s)
- ___/0.2 – Date
- ___/0.3 – Article title
- ___/0.3 – Journal title
- ___/0.1 – Volume & issue
- ___/0.1 – Page range/ ID
- ___/0.2 – DOI

For a news/ website article:

- ___/0.1 – Alphabetic order
- ___/0.1 – Hanging indent
- ___/0.3 – Article in-text citation
- ___/0.2 – Author(s)
- ___/0.3 – Date
- ___/0.4 – Article title
- ___/0.4 – News/ website name
- ___/0.2 – URL